A24 AND THE ASIAN AMERICAN PRESTIGE FILM

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In March 2023, *Everything Everywhere All at Once* (Daniel Kwan and Daniel Scheinert, 2022) took home seven Academy Awards and became the first Asian American–themed and –authored film to win Best Picture, Best Actress, and Best Director. A flurry of jubilant think pieces and news articles celebrating the Oscars' significance for Asian Americans followed. An AP News piece, entitled "For Asian Americans, Yeoh, Quan's Oscar Wins Are Theirs Too," included a sampling of typical responses: "That's my mother's story," said one fan who came to the United States as a Vietnamese refugee. Norman Chen, CEO of the Asian American Foundation, is quoted as saying that "the recognition is there finally" and that "this changes the whole mindset for the community—even for our families."[1] In their telling, the Oscar triumph was bigger than the movie, and an indication of progress and acceptance in a country that has long treated Asian Americans as outsiders.[2]

This feeling of "arrival" is the culmination of a steady climb toward awards-season success for Asian American films. In 2020, Awkwafina became the first Asian American to win Best Actress at the Golden Globe Awards for *The Farewell* (Lulu Wang, 2019). At the Oscars the following year, *Minari* (Lee Isaac Chung, 2020) was nominated for Best Picture, Best Director, and Best Actor, and Youn Yuh-jung won for Best Supporting Actress. Meanwhile, *Everything Everywhere All at Once* was not the only Asian American film of note during the 2022–23 awards season. *After Yang* (2021) picked up multiple nominations and wins from critics' associations for its Korean American writer-director, Kogonada. If "recognition is there finally," it is the result of years of chipping away at Hollywood's whitewashing of Asian American stories.

Upon closer look, however, this narrative of improved representation and eventual mainstream acceptance is complicated by a fact that may be no coincidence: all four of these films—*The Farewell*, *Minari*, *After Yang*, and *Everything Everywhere All at Once*—as well as *Past Lives* (Celine Song, 2023), which as of this writing is preparing its own awards-season run, are distributed by the studio A24, one of Hollywood's most successful independent producer-distributor-financiers, and one that is responsible for another Best Picture winner, *Moonlight* (Barry Jenkins, 2016). As is well established, the Oscars are no simple meritocracy. Getting nominated requires capital-intensive "For Your Consideration" (FYC) campaigns, celebrity networking and endorsements, and a persistent public-relations strategy pushing appealing narratives about the particular film and its makers. "Recognition" thus is not just recognition from Oscar voters, but recognition by a major indie studio like A24 that Asian American films are a financial risk worth taking.

A24 has established a winning blueprint for what I am calling the "Asian American prestige film," a package of discourses around race, independent film, and Asian American representation that appeals to both Oscar voters and Asian American filmgoers ready to venerate the films on social media and in journalistic writing. Through paratexts that shape journalistic and fan discourse and generate the momentum necessary to win over the Academy, whose members are not historically Asian American, A24 has wrapped its Asian American productions in an aura of prestige. Specifically, A24 uses discourses of cultural authenticity, often around familiar and legible narratives of Asian immigrant families, to position these films as "quality" works worthy of official recognition. A24's success in achieving this goal speaks to a moment when Hollywood insiders both recognize the industry's historical inability to represent Asian stories and desperately want to commend any efforts at correcting this failing.

Distributing Asian American Film

Studies of Asian American film typically focus on production and reception—the traditional sites of meaning making in the media, what Stuart Hall calls its "determinate

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Awkwafina (center) in *The Farewell.*

moments."[3] Less has been discussed of distribution, which might be seen as a discursive mediator between producers and audiences, since it includes the process by which films are marketed and strategically positioned in theaters in the distributors' given territory. Distributors of substantial stature and ambition also serve as producers and/or financiers, influencing key production elements like budget, casting, and script. As films enter awards season, distributors continue to play a part, responding to audience reactions to reshape the films' meanings and significance.

There is a practical reason Asian American film scholars have not discussed distribution: few Asian American films have been represented by theatrical distributors. Jun Okada's *Making Asian American Film and Video*, which explicitly looks at the institutions of Asian American cinema, examines media organizations like Visual Communications and public television stations, but not theatrical distributors.[4] Another key text covering Asian American media institutions, Kent A. Ono and Vincent N. Pham's *Asian Americans and the Media*, even assumes that Asian American cinema has a "lack of wide distribution" and thus needs alternative distribution channels like film festivals.[5] Indeed, between 1980, the year *Hito Hata: Raise the Banner* (Robert Nakamura) became the first self-consciously Asian American feature film, and 2009, the year of Ono and Pham's book, few Asian American narrative films were distributed theatrically by what Yannis Tzioumakis calls the "mini-majors and major independents," the distribution companies that helped to usher in the American independent film movement of the 1980s and 1990s.[6] That no major independents distributed more than three features across nearly three decades speaks to how none invested in Asian American cinema as a movement, let alone helped to define its discursive contours.

Considering that historical context, A24's acquisition or funding of five Asian American films over four years—as well its involvement in the high-profile TV series *Beef* (2023) and the forthcoming *The Sympathizer* (HBO)—stands out as a palpable shift for Indiewood. Examining A24's larger strategy within the current distribution landscape might explain this unprecedented interest. Founded in 2012 by three industry veterans representing backgrounds in film finance, independent distribution, and independent production, A24, like other new studios such as Annapurna, found success by rethinking distribution in light of the rise of streaming. These "late indie" studios differed from the previous generation of independent distributors by diversifying film slates (such as including both genre films and art cinema) and investing in other media like television and gaming.[7] Quick to establish a market outside of traditional art houses, A24 struck key relationships with nontheatrical partners like Amazon Video and DirecTV for subscription and video-on-demand streaming distribution. This had the effect of guaranteeing a revenue stream as well as reaching a younger, national audience not historically well served

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by the "aging specialty sector" centered around New York City art houses.[8]

A24 films like *Spring Breakers* (Harmony Korine, 2012), *The Bling Ring* (Sofia Coppola, 2013), and *Lady Bird* (Greta Gerwig, 2017) reflect that more youthful orientation. In addition to films for and about young people, A24 also became synonymous with "prestige horror," exemplified by the films of Alex Garland, Ari Aster, and Robert Eggers, as well as new films by established auteurs (Kelly Reichardt, Noah Baumbach) and eventually lower-budget dramas about racial issues in the United States like *Moonlight* and *The Last Black Man in San Francisco* (Joe Talbot, 2019).[9] Uniting such films of different genres and sensibilities is the notion of "prestige," though not the upscale, elite version popularized by American independent cinema in the 1980s and 1990s. Rather, it is prestige with street cred, encapsulated by a *Fast Company* article that sized up A24 with the question "[W]hat if Miramax, but also Supreme?," referring to the coveted and instantly recognizable streetwear brand.[10]

A24's aura of exclusivity as a hip brand targeting Gen Z and millennials is fueled not just by its films, but by its merchandise and membership program. Film-distribution companies typically produce a small portfolio of PR texts for each release: press kit, poster, trailer. A24 goes straight to the consumer, dropping merchandise the way shoe brands do, with an emphasis on design and collectability. The studio's infamous membership program gives loyal fans a first look at the latest merchandise releases, as well as access to exclusive social-media posts through a "close friendship" on Instagram. Typical merchandise might include zines, books, T-shirts, collectable toys, vinyl soundtracks, and mementos based on props from A24's films. Multiple articles have termed this the "cult of A24" to describe the cachet the company has for seducing consumers with pop prestige in a social-media age.[11]

How does Asian America fit within this palace of cool? If past distributors proved allergic to Asian American independent film, why did it appeal to A24? For one, A24 has attached itself to Asian American films with stars recognizable to millennial TV and Internet consumers. *Minari*'s Steven Yeun was the breakout star of AMC's *The Walking Dead*, *Past Lives*'s Greta Lee had a key supporting role in Netflix's *Russian Doll*, and *The Farewell*'s Awkwafina was a cult hip-hop personality on YouTube before her Hollywood breakthrough with *Crazy Rich Asians* (Jon M. Chu, 2018). More savvy than mere casting, though, is A24's ability to appeal to young audiences' concerns about diversity, representation, and authenticity—an appeal that, coupled with A24's reputation as a distributor of edgy, relevant films, also found favor among critics and Oscar voters.

If the Miramax generation of indie distributors downplayed diversity to court mainstream audiences, A24



***Minari*'s cast includes Steven Yeun (left), a star recognizable to millennial viewers.**

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belongs to a generation motivated by #OscarsSoWhite campaigns. Writing on 1990s and early 2000s LGBT-themed films, Joseph Cabosky and Stuart Richards both show how Indiewood distributors deemphasized queerness in mainstream marketing and awards-season "For Your Consideration" campaigns.[12] In those cases, prestige necessitated the marginalization of difference. On the other hand, in the 2020s, A24 has foregrounded the Asian American–ness of its Oscar contenders, as seen through its promotional materials—finding in cultural difference an asset for an industry reckoning with its continued missteps in representing filmmakers and actors of color. In that context, the version of Asian American–ness that A24 embraces is one that highlights difference and values of cultural "authenticity," especially around the immigrant experience. If Hollywood and the Academy Awards have long celebrated a whitewashed version of screen Asians, A24 would counter this with explicit and unassailable Asian authenticity.

Cultural "authenticity," of course, is contested, politically fraught, and arguably impossible, but it offers useful rhetoric for an industry battling its own demons. If Hollywood's Asian-themed films have been criticized for being directed by white filmmakers, Asian American authorial authenticity is insurance against criticisms of improper representation. A24's five Asian American films to date are directed by Asian Americans, the minimal gesture of dignifying Asian American authorship. That three of those five films are autobiographical allows A24 to ensure the link between authorship and authenticity. *Minari* is based on director Lee Isaac Chung's family's story of moving to the American South, while *The Farewell* and *Past Lives* are based on their directors' experiences of being caught between pressures both from the places of their birth (China and Korea, respectively) and from their adopted homes in the United States.

Conscious of the cash value of authenticity, A24 augments the filmmakers' sensitive portrayals of their own experiences on-screen with paratextual materials that underscore the films' autobiographical elements. While none of the marketing strategies they employ are wholly original, their application to Asian American films at a moment of anxiety over racial difference stands out. For instance, *Minari*'s press notes, designed to spark story ideas for journalists, play up Lee Isaac Chung's personal investment in the film. *Minari* is described as "the film he always wanted to make: a deeply personal immersion into reconciling two worlds." The notes detail Chung's Arkansas upbringing and its resonance in the film, drawing a clear line from the autobiographical to the creative process. In the notes, Chung is quoted as saying, "I wrote down eighty visual memories from when I was right around my daughter's age. They ranged from my parents' heated arguments in Arkansas, to a man who worked for my father dragging a cross around town, to my grandmother burning down half of our farm. Looking through them I thought, maybe this is the story I've wanted to tell all along." A24's *Minari* merchandise follows similarly, highlighting Chung's personal connection. The published screenplay of the film, available on A24's website, includes "annotated photographs from Isaac's own childhood family albums." From Chung's family story, A24 extrapolates an authenticity to the larger Korean American experience. The A24 website also includes printable recipe cards "from the *Minari* family table to yours," a series of four illustrated recipes of Korean cuisine as cooked by the film's actors or their Korean moms. Lee Isaac Chung and *Minari* star Steven Yeun also coedited an issue of A24's zine series. Entitled *Family Business*, it profiles eleven family businesses that, like the one depicted in *Minari*, exemplify typical American values of hard work and immigrant success. Importantly, six of the family businesses are of Asian American immigrant families, further tying the film's depiction of a family farm to a larger, real-life social phenomenon. In their introduction, Chung and Yeun affirm their credentials to tell these stories: "Business is in the blood of the Yeun and Chung families," it begins.[13]

The extracinematic discourse around *The Farewell* and *Past Lives* similarly underscores the autobiographical. An entire page of the press notes for *The Farewell* is dedicated to director Lulu Wang's "real story" behind the film, and two more pages are dedicated to the process of converting truth to fiction, including how the film adapts Wang's own sense of culture clash, how she wrote the script in English first, and how she defined authenticity in casting.[14] The ethic of self-representation is also a theme of the *Past Lives* press notes, which describe Celine Song's film as "a deeply personal story that she knew only she could direct." In contrast to past Hollywood films that relied on non-Asian directors to tell Asian stories, A24 wants commentators to know that they are the studio that will finally create the platform for authentic authorship.

These narratives of authenticity were amplified by journalists along the Oscar campaign trail. NPR's *Fresh Air* ran a story entitled "Lee Isaac Chung Jotted Down Some Family Memories—They Became 'Minari.'"[15] The *New York Times* ran an article on *The Farewell* with the headline "A Family's Real-Life Lie and the Movie That Complicated It."[16] The *Los Angeles Times*'s interview with Celine Song is entitled "How a First-Time Director's

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Colin Farrell as the Asiaphile Jake in *After Yang*.

Own 'Past Lives' Inspired One of the Year's Best Films."[17] Taking their lead from the distributor, journalists are able to intervene, too, in controversies over Hollywood cultural inauthenticity, by showcasing independent film voices that emphasize the autobiographical, thereby challenging the whitewashing of Asian American stories.

A24 also performs cultural authenticity through statements of linguistic proficiency. One impressed journalist, Lisa Wong Macabasco, starts her post-Oscars exultation of *Everything Everywhere All at Once* with an anecdote. Arriving to interview directors Daniel Kwan and Daniel Scheinert, she was handed a pronunciation guide for the actors' Sinophone names. She recounts some of its helpful hints: "Michelle Yeoh's surname should be pronounced 'yo,' Stephanie Hsu's is 'shoe,' Ke Huy Quan's name is pronounced 'Key Hway Kwan' and the surname of the family at the center of the movie (Wang) rhymes with 'song.'"[18] The emphasis on correct pronunciation not only speaks to the studio's performance of authenticity and its sensitivity to actors' preferences, but also assumes that in a post-#OscarsSoWhite context, journalists have a desire to respect difference and appreciate a studio that can help them navigate it. Similarly, A24's press notes play the part of cultural translator. The *Minari* press notes begin by defining the film's Korean title. The *Past Lives* press notes contains an entire section on the Korean word "in-yun," a concept that plays a notable role in the film's narrative. These linguistic guides, along with the bilingual *Minari* script available on A24's website, make the studio akin to Colin Farrell's character in *After Yang*, the Asiaphile who speaks confidently of ethnic authenticity. And like the Chinese tea that Farrell's character brews and sells, A24's Asian American films, representing the culture wing of the studio's film slate (which also includes prestige horror and elevated young adult films), are presented with care and an air of refinement.

The Asian American Prestige Film

Historically, studies of "quality" or "prestige" American film and television focus on productions featuring white characters or works by white male authors.[19] Period dramas and literary adaptations likewise encourage the association between "quality" and whiteness.[20] Yet there is another strain of "quality" film and television that suggests that nonwhite works have found a seat at the prestige table. An award-strewn lineage that includes directors and showrunners from Spike Lee to Donald Glover and *Master of None*'s Aziz Ansari prepared the ground for the rise of A24's Asian American prestige film.[21]

Chris Cagle points out the need to think about the prestige film in its historic and industrial context,

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noting the emergence of the high-gloss adaptation (such as the Oscar-winning *Dodsworth* [William Wyler, 1936]) in the prewar period and the social-problem film (such as the Oscar-winning *Marty* [Delbert Mann, 1955]) in the postwar years.[22] Following Cagle's argument, contemporary "quality" would include works that appear to pierce through the industry's racial homogeneity, an issue that's seen as symptomatic of larger societal inequalities that include antiblack policing, the inhumane treatment of refugees, and anti-Asian violence. If today's "social problems" involve racial inequality, however superficially diagnosed or treated, then diverse stories and "authentic" authorship are the new prestige. If the Academy Awards are a barometer for Hollywood's values of "quality," this shift to diversity-as-prestige can be seen in the fact that the Best Picture awards presented between 2017 and 2023 were all for films about diversity issues and/or directed by nonwhite or foreign-born filmmakers. In this climate, seemingly authentic diversity is currency, and awards like the Oscars are symbolic and represent financial capital accrued through investment in diverse commodities.[23]

However, not any diversity will do. After all, Asian Americans have been making narrative features for decades without interest from major distribution companies or the Oscars. Common thematic threads across A24's five Asian American films to date delineate a specific version of Asian American self-representation that is especially exploitable. All five address cultural difference without touching on the more uncomfortable themes of anti-Asian racism. *The Farewell* is about a Chinese American's moral crisis while visiting China, moving the conflict of cultural marginalization from the United States to another country. As a drama of immigration to the United States in the 1980s, *Minari* describes racial friction but cautiously surprises the audience, which might expect racism to be around every corner, reminding them that not all white southerners are racist. *Everything Everywhere All at Once*'s cultural conflict is intergenerational rather than interracial: the Asian versus American tensions are between an immigrant mother and her queer daughter who strives to live her own life. *After Yang* does depict a white–Asian misunderstanding—in this case, between a white father and the "Chinese" robot he purchased for his Chinese adoptee daughter—but the racial dynamics between man and AI are allegorical rather than explicit, and hardly critique the more trenchant questions of techno-Orientalism. Lastly, *Past Lives*'s love triangle between a Korean immigrant woman, her white American husband, and her childhood sweetheart, who visits from Korea, is dramatically effective to the extent that it convinces the audience that the white guy isn't that bad.

All five of A24's films focus on immigrants, and all except *Past Lives* are about Chinese or Korean immigrant families. The immigration film, with its capacity to romanticize the rocky road to American assimilation and celebrate



The love triangle at the heart of *Past Lives*.

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neoliberal ideals of hard work, self-reliance, and family bonds in the face of a hostile host country, is a relatively safe genre for touching on "social problems." From the perspective of second-generation immigrant filmmakers, especially those chronicling their own experiences, the films are told in the past tense: a conflict that once was, that has made the filmmakers who they are now. Social problems with family solutions are ripe for exploitation as prestigious cinema—a strategy that is plainly on view in A24's shifting marketing of *Everything Everywhere All at Once* when it discovered it had an awards contender on its hands. When the film was first released in March 2022, A24 marketed it as the kind of comedic genre mash-up one would expect from auteurs like Kwan and Scheinert, who had directed a previous A24 comedy, *Swiss Army Man* (2016). In A24's original press notes, the synopsis for the film reads:

> Directed by Daniel Kwan and Daniel Scheinert, collectively known as Daniels, *Everything Everywhere All at Once* is a hilarious and big-hearted sci-fi action adventure about an exhausted Chinese American woman (Michelle Yeoh) who can't seem to finish her taxes.

The jokey, mischievous focus on not finishing one's taxes was also the topic of the Daniels' zine for A24, entitled *Tax Season*, a tongue-in-cheek, "unscientific dive into the US tax system, featuring interviews with former IRS agents, a guide to tax avoidance, and stories of multiple astronauts who have requested filing extensions from space."[24] However, as the months went by and the film started to gain traction with critics and audiences, becoming A24's highest-grossing film ever, and gaining awards buzz, A24 shifted its marketing emphasis, retooling the film from zany sci-fi to immigrant-family story, albeit with fantastical elements. The synopsis accompanying the film's "For Your Consideration" materials now reads:

> When an interdimensional rupture threatens to unravel reality, the fate of the world is suddenly in the hands of a most unlikely hero: Evelyn, an overwhelmed immigrant mother. As bewildering dangers emerge from the multiverse, she must channel her newfound powers to save her home and her family.[25]

Gone is the mention of sci-fi or hilarity, the more low-art sell of the original synopsis. Present now is the mention of an immigrant and her plight to save her home and family. The "Chinese American woman" is now no longer at the mercy of her taxes, but is the agent of change—the immigrant as superhero. The Daniels' auteurism, once the great marker of cinematic quality, makes way for an inspiring allegory of the immigrant-family experience with the might of Marvel characters. Indie quirk is transformed into Asian American prestige.

Prestige as Plasticity

While A24's shifting strategy proved astute and successful, it also shows the extent to which Asian American–ness is molded and performed rather than authentically cultivated. The studio's marketing seeks to have it both ways, catering to gatekeepers' perceptions of Asian American narratives while performing authenticity as a quality of that narrative. I don't contend that such a pure or authentic voice exists or should even be sought, but rather that in Indiewood, authenticity has become an illusory target—and a potentially profitable one. Yet this tension between shaping authenticity and finding it lies at the heart of so many contradictions of both independent cinema and "Asian America" as an identity category. Geoff King tackles the former through the analogy "indie as organic," arguing that the "independence" of independent film might be understood through agricultural notions of purity, sustainability, and healthiness. He extends that analogy to independent film's values of authentic authorship, intellectual and moral "healthiness," and honesty in marketing. As in the food industry, King argues, "organic" discourses in film become a brand that can in turn be commodified, even against its own ideals.[26]

Given its rural settings and real-life inspirations, *Minari* makes for a useful case study in how "organic discourses" of American independent cinema can be complicated by race—a topic that is typically unaccounted for in theorizations of indie cinema. The film's authorship has been discussed above with regard to A24's highlighting autobiography as authenticity and its underscoring of the film's "rootedness" in Lee Isaac Chung's experience of the American South. I would add that before it was a coproduction of A24 and Plan B Entertainment, *Minari* was known as *Vapour of Smoke*, an autobiographical sketch of Chung's parents' story. In 2014, Chung took the treatment for *Vapour of Smoke* to the Busan International Film Festival's Asian Project Market to look for funding and partners. At the market, the film was listed as a US-Korean project produced by Chung's long-time collaborators Eugene Suen and Samuel Gray Anderson. However, when the film was announced as an A24/Plan B film in 2019, Suen and

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A24's promotion of *Minari* emphasized the film's salutary effects.

Anderson had been replaced by a team that had previously produced the A24/Plan B films *Moonlight* and *The Last Black Man in San Francisco*. The new producing team had the pedigree and experience to complete the film and interest critics, but they severed the film's "roots," as idealized by independent cinema's "organic" discourses of authorial authenticity.

With regard to the film's "healthiness," A24 did not shy away from proposing some nourishing "effects" of the film. One of the primary movie posters for the film features, in large text, a quote from the *Los Angeles Times* that reads: "This is the movie we need right now." The poster's image is of an Asian American family, holding hands while bathed in pastoral backlight, standing on grass with an American flag in the background. Against this image, the "we" of the quote refers to "America" and the "need" might refer to the imperative of taking seriously a diverse America in the wake of the George Floyd murder mere months before the film's theatrical release in December 2020. Interestingly, the quote takes on a different meaning in the original *Los Angeles Times* film review, which argued that the film's "gentle" and "sweet" approach to family is the perfect antidote to an "exhausting 2020" marked by "unrest," "pain," and a global pandemic.[27] By recontextualizing the quote, A24's marketing team turns the film from comfort food to vegetables, a film that America "needs" to reckon with its moral cultural crisis. In other words, the film is now important and essential—perhaps award-worthy.

This marketing intervention shows A24's treatment of racial discourse as a commodity to mold, package, and market, even if somewhat dishonestly—a tactic that King notes is typical in mainstream Hollywood but antithetical to the imagined independent spirit. Yet, in seeking social prestige, A24 understands the countervailing need to preserve a semblance of the film's cultural rootedness, especially as it is simultaneously pitching Asian American authenticity as a core value.

In both independent cinema and Asian America, authenticity is negotiated, tested, and defined through romantic notions of community, whether that is the local art-house theater or a Chinatown facing gentrification. Historically, film festivals are spaces where the idea of community is activated, where independent filmmakers and their distributors build audiences, and where localized conversations around films take place. For Asian American independent cinema, the Asian American film-festival circuit is often the primary distribution channel. Beyond providing access to theaters and audiences, these festivals, Ono and Pham argue, are a space of opposition, advocacy, and convocation.[28] Erin Franziska Högerle adds that Asian American film festivals also do authenticity work, framing films to shape and "represent" a communal history and experience.[29]

As a major indie studio, A24 does not rely on the film-festival circuit for its marketing in the way a smaller distributor might. It typically gives its films world premieres at festivals with major media presences (*Minari* and *Past Lives* at Sundance, *Everything Everywhere All at Once* at SXSW, and *After Yang* at Cannes) and skips "niche" festivals, shifting to broad, national social-media campaigns that involve everything from pitched articles, merchandise, member content, and prepackaged animated GIFs on its GIPHY channel. This national and centralized approach gives A24 full control over the carefully calibrated marketing narrative and how individual communities perceive and value its products. Yet, the Asian American film-festival circuit is still useful in providing the kind of authenticity and community validation that a Hollywood studio like A24 can't conjure with only press kits.

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An invitation to a special Korean American Day screening of *Minari*.

For *Minari*, rather than playing the film at individual Asian American film festivals, A24 opted to mobilize twelve of the larger festivals for one virtual screening in celebration of Korean American Day on January 13, 2021. The screening was followed by a conversation between Chung, the film's cast, and a celebrity moderator (Sandra Oh) hand-selected by the A24 team. A24 provided each film festival an "exclusive" virtual-screening-room link, branded with the festival's own logo, and a social-media graphic, also with the organization's own logo, to market to its audiences as its "own" screening. Doing so allowed A24 to control the screening time and presentation, to shape the conversation around race and authenticity that followed the screening, to activate local institutions trusted by their local Asian American communities, to market to audiences hungry for Asian American independent film, and to spark validating articles from Asian American perspectives. Such articles soon appeared on the websites of organizations like Reappropriate, the Asian American Christian Collaborative, and the *Korea Herald*, all of which specifically cited the Korean American Day screening and the Q&A that followed.[30] Such copy-and-paste marketing manufactures both uniformity and exclusivity, the national and the local.

It is, in other words, the "synthetic malleability" of what Kristin J. Warner defines as "plastic representation."[31] Warner observes that campaigns like #OscarsSoWhite have led to superficial nods towards diversity—one-dimensional characters that can be sold, often to much fanfare, as the same commodities but in new colors. With A24, it is not necessarily the film texts themselves that pander to the multiculturalist gaze, but the paratexts of distribution that discursively meld the meaning of those texts into the proper plastic molding. Plasticity is the opposite of the organic. But with the case of A24, plastics can manufacture Oscars, even to the delight of some Asian American commentators. Melissa Phruksachart attributes this irony to the cult of what she calls "messianic visibility," whereby Asian American audiences, so starved of cinematic representation, presumably are cured of their racial psychoses merely by being seen on-screen—or marketed to as a consumer.[32] The Oscar stage, like the Ivy Leagues, is perhaps cinema's most prominent example of illusory meritocratic prestige and glass-ceiling-busting arrival, and thus fodder for the desire for visibility apparent in the quotations at the beginning of this article. Legible discourses of the immigrant family and of Asian American authenticity unlock those gilded doors and invite acclaim and prestige as "quality" cinema.

These are, of course, not the first Asian American films to safely center immigrant families. Earlier films like Mira Nair's *The Namesake* (2006), a star-driven immigrant-family tale based on a best-selling novel, might have been similarly feted as quality Oscar bait had its distributor, Fox Searchlight, felt it profitable or worthy at the time. The genre's recent emergence as "prestige" shows that quality is a historical construction. Furthermore, "quality" assumes that something else is "not quality." The obvious "lesser" films would be the countless Hollywood productions that have dehumanized Asian Americans through caricature or whitewashing, from *The Good Earth* (Sidney Franklin, 1937) and *Breakfast at Tiffany's* (Blake Edwards, 1961) to *Indiana Jones and the Temple of Doom* (Steven Spielberg, 1984) and *Ghost in the Shell* (Rupert Sanders, 2017). As Warner and Phruksachart note, with such a low bar, more-"progressive"

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films might be celebrated simply for casting actual Asian Americans or not being explicitly racist. Here, prestige requires only presence.

However, another set of films might be the "nonquality" foil against which this new batch of prestige Asian American cinema is defined: the underdistributed Asian American independent films of the past forty-plus years. If prestige is a function of highbrow attention, films without theatrical distribution cannot reach critical mass without access to theaters, marketing, and journalistic writing with its awards-season prognosticating. But surveying this body of work reveals a much broader set of thematic, stylistic, and generic preoccupations than is represented by A24's five tales of Asian American immigrants.[33]

The earlier wave of Asian American independent film included many narratives about cultural conflict and immigrant families, such as *The Wedding Banquet* (Ang Lee, 1993) and *Journey from the Fall* (Ham Tran, 2006). As such stories became a cliché of Asian American cinema—however resonant they remained—filmmakers actively explored alternatives, from queer musicals like *Fruit Fly* (H. P. Mendoza, 2009) to buddy horror-comedy like *Crush the Skull* (Viet Nguyen, 2015) and countless other genres and themes. Importantly, trends emerged that challenged the legibility of Asian American cinema as a political category and economic commodity. Some Asian American films, such as *Cavite* (Neill Dela Llana and Ian Gamazon, 2005) and *Go Back to China* (Emily Ting, 2019), can be set in Asia rather than the United States, breaking from the long-held resolution that Asian American stories are "American" stories. A number of Asian American filmmakers have preferred an assimilationist, postracial route, whereby characters on-screen "just happen to be Asian," rather than having been explicitly written with a set of ethnic specificities in mind. At the far end of postracial identity are filmmakers like Gregg Araki and Karyn Kusama, who self-identify as Asian American but who do not make films that center Asian American characters.[34]

Looking beyond A24 as the benchmark of Asian American cinema, one finds Strand Releasing, founded in 1989 by Marcus Hu and Jon Gerrans, which has distributed nine generically transgressive Asian American features. Strand's catalogue includes films as categorically diverse as the experimental eco-satire *Fresh Kill* (Shu Lea Cheang, 1994), the Islamic punk-rock portrait *The Taqwacores* (Eyad Zahra, 2010), the queer dramas *Front Cover* (Ray Yeung, 2015) and *Spa Night* (Andrew Ahn, 2016), and the amorphous art films *Mogul Mowgli* (Bassam Tariq, 2020) and *I Was a Simple Man* (Christopher Makoto Yogi, 2021). Strand has also issued new restorations of Wayne Wang's films and distributed Araki's early works. Collectively, these works render Asian American cinema as messy and irreducible.

Certain Tendencies of Asian American Cinema

In the broader independent landscape, which includes the festival circuit, mainstream legibility through Asian American immigrant-family stories was never the sole calling. Echoing Francois Truffaut's own argument against authenticity and traditions of quality, Gregg Araki once railed against "Asian Americans who eat sushi, take their shoes off in the house, and only make films about the camps and fortune cookie factories."[35] He refuses the accepted expectations of Asian American identity and filmmaking. Like Araki, *Minari* director Lee Isaac Chung had for years been a prime example of the Asian American director who makes non-Asian films, such as the Rwanda-set *Munyurangabo* (2007) and *I Have Seen My Last Born* (with Samuel Gray Anderson, 2015), the Gerald Stern–inspired *Lucky Life* (2010), and the shape-shifting *Abigail Harm* (2012), starring Amanda Plummer. Defending his Rwandan films in 2018, Chung asked, "Why do I need to make a film about the Asian American experience? I feel like even that comes from cultural institutions where they say, 'Well, you are a Korean American. You need to.'"[36] Chung doesn't specify which cultural institutions he's referring to, including whether they are Asian centered or not. Regardless, his annoyance that legible ethnic boxes are how status-endowing institutions define the correct path for Asian Americans aligns him with a wave of other Asian American artists and scholars who have challenged the tokenizing and disciplinary logic of multiculturalism in gatekeeper institutions such as distribution companies. In the face of such gatekeeping and surveillance, Susette Min calls for Asian American art to be "unnamable," while Vivian L. Huang reappropriates the "inscrutable" to slip free from capitalism's assimilationist gaze.[37]

Asian American independent film has long been a productive category for the possibilities it opens up rather than for its status as clearly identifiable "Asian American content" on a distributor's diversity balance sheet. Strand Releasing's distribution strategy accounts for that more inclusive and explosive possibility, rendering Asian American cinema as chameleonlike, blending into queer cinema, art cinema, and international film. A24's approach instead runs a highlighter through a film's authentic Asian American qualities while promoting the company's position as cultural translator, and its close ties to Asian American

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community groups. These efforts have won A24 awards, cultural cachet, and economic standing. I don't want to take credit away from the filmmakers, nor do I want to deny the sentiments expressed by the Asian American viewers cited at the beginning of this article, much as they align with A24's carefully calibrated narrative. The hunger for recognition and to be awarded exists for a reason. But when the terms of self-love are green-lighted by a Hollywood minimajor with much to gain from histrionic declarations of authenticity, narrative possibilities that defy identitarian notions of "authenticity" are eclipsed and the hard-fought inclusivity of Asian American cinema narrows. When A24 profits from the Asian American prestige film, there is a false sense that status for Asian Americans will follow. To put it another way, instead of asking how A24 produced the Asian American prestige film, one should ask why Asian American cinematic, journalistic, and emotional labor is producing A24's prestige.

Notes

1. Terry Tang, "For Asian Americans, Yeoh, Quan's Oscar Wins Are Theirs Too," AP News, March 13, 2023, https://apnews.com/article/oscars-asian-michelle-yeoh-ke-huy-quan-041c1f2adee40d60f85c1ae51213b9ff.
2. Jason Coe summarizes some of the responses by Asian American commentators in "Everything Everywhere All at Once and the Intimate Public of Asian American Cinema," *Film Quarterly* 76, no. 4 (Summer 2023): 36–37.
3. Stuart Hall, "Encoding and Decoding in the Televisual Discourse," in *Essential Essays*, vol. 1, *Foundations of Cultural Studies*, ed. David Morley (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2019), 259–60.
4. Jun Okada, *Making Asian American Film and Video: Histories, Institutions, Movements* (New Brunswick, NJ: Rutgers University Press, 2015).
5. Kent A. Ono and Vincent N. Pham, *Asian Americans and the Media* (Cambridge: Polity, 2009) 121.
6. Yannis Tzioumakis, "After the 'Great Studio Pullback of '08': Late Indiewood and American Independent Theatrical Distribution in the Age of Streaming (2008-2019)," *Media Industries* 10.1 (2023) https://journals.publishing.umich.edu/mij/article/id/1482/.

   During the 1980s and 1990s, Orion Classics, Skouras, Samuel Goldwyn, and Magnolia released two Asian American features each. IFC Films released three between 2006 and 2008. New Yorker Films never released another Asian American feature after its success with *Chan Is Missing* (Wayne Wang) in 1982, while Miramax, Sony Pictures Classics, and Fox Searchlight, three of the leading Indiewood distributors during these decades, each released only one—*Picture Bride* (Kayo Hatta, 1994), *Saving Face* (Alice Wu, 2004), and *The Namesake* (Mira Nair, 2006), respectively—in those years. The bulk of Asian American narrative features were self-released, unreleased, or distributed by small fly-by-night companies like Phaedra (five features), Indican (four features), and Emerging Pictures (three features).
7. Tzioumakis, ibid.
8. Ryan David Briggs, "A Tale of Two Indies: Amazon Studios and A24 in the Streaming Age," *Velvet Light Trap* 90 (Fall 2022): 9–10.
9. Kristin Thompson discusses the recent "prestige" and "elevated" horror subgenres in Kristin Thompson and David Bordwell, "How Did 'Prestige Horror' Come About?," *Observations on Film Art* (blog), May 6, 2022, http://www.davidbordwell.net/blog/2022/05/06/how-did-prestige-horror-come-about/.
10. Joe Berkowitz, "I Spent Six Weeks Living in A24-World. Here's What Happened," Fast Company, June 27, 2022, www.fastcompany.com/90764124/i-spent-six-weeks-living-a24-world-aaa24-membership-what-happened.
11. For instance, see Nate Jones, "The Cult of A24," Vulture, August 24, 2022, www.vulture.com/article/a24-movies-cult.html; and Simran Hans, "The Cult of A24," *ArtReview*, August 19, 2022, https://artreview.com/the-cult-of-a24/.
12. Joseph Cabosky, "For Your Consideration: A Critical Analysis of LGBT-themed Film Award Campaign Advertisements: 1990–2005," *Journalism History* 41, no. 2 (Summer 2015): 73–84; Stuart Richards, "Overcoming the Stigma: The Queer Denial of Indiewood," *Journal of Film and Video* 68, no. 1 (Spring 2016): 19–30.
13. Lee Isaac Chung and Steven Yeun, "From the Editors," *Family Business*, A24 Zine #15, 2. https://a24films.com/notes/2021/04/issue-15-family-business
14. Wang also had the opportunity to edit an A24 zine on the occasion of *The Farewell*'s release. Entitled *First Gen*, it, like Chung and Yeun's *Family Business*, gives voice to others who have experienced immigrant cross-cultural challenges like the characters in *The Farewell*. A scrapbook of memories, family photos, and reflections by mostly Asian American creatives like musician Michelle Zauner and comedian Hasan Minhaj, *First Gen* multiplies the story of *The Farewell* into a number of "real-life" directions, tying the "authentic" autobiography of *The Farewell* to a larger movement of Asian American immigrant artists and writers telling their own stories.
15. "Lee Isaac Chung Jotted Down Some Family Memories—They Became 'Minari'," *NPR* (March 3, 2021) https://www.npr.org/transcripts/973262034

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16. Robert Ito, "A Family's Real-Life Lie and the Movie That Complicated It," *New York Times*, July 5, 2019, www.nytimes.com/2019/07/05/movies/farewell-wang-awkwafina.html.
17. Carlos Aguilar, "How a First-Time Director's Own 'Past Lives' Inspired One of the Year's Best Films," *Los Angeles Times*, June 2, 2023, www.latimes.com/entertainment-arts/movies/story/2023-06-02/past-lives-a24-celine-song-greta-lee.
18. Lisa Wong Macabasco, "What *Everything Everywhere All at Once*'s Oscars Win Means for Asian American Representation," *The Guardian*, March 13, 2023, www.theguardian.com/film/2023/mar/13/everything-everywhere-asian-representation-oscars-sweep.
19. See, for instance, Robert J. Thompson, *Television's Second Golden Age: From "Hill Street Blues" to "ER"* (Syracuse, NY: Syracuse University Press, 1997); and Geoff King, *Quality Hollywood: Markers of Distinction in Contemporary Studio Film* (London: I. B. Tauris, 2016).
20. For a discussion of the way that class and sexuality are bound by the industrial and generic expectations of the "quality period drama," see Eve Ng, "The 'Gentleman-like' Anne Lister on *Gentleman Jack*: Queerness, Class, and Prestige in 'Quality' Period Dramas," *International Journal of Communication* 15 (2021): 2397–2417.
21. Bringing together these strains are period works that insert nonwhite characters into traditionally white stories, a form of stunt casting that uses "color blindness" to safely and proudly announce its diversity without addressing its politics. Examples include *The Personal History of David Copperfield* (Armando Iannucci, 2019), *Bridgerton* (Netflix, 2020–), and *Anne Boleyn* (Channel 5, 2021).
22. Chris Cagle, *Sociology on Film: Postwar Hollywood's Prestige Commodity* (New Brunswick, NJ: Rutgers University Press, 2017) 19–23.
23. For a discussion of the "cultural economics" of awards like the Oscars, and the relationship between cultural prestige and economic capital, see James F. English, *The Economy of Prestige: Prizes, Awards, and the Circulation of Cultural Value* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2005).
24. "Tax Season Zine by Daniels," A24, https://shop.a24films.com/products/tax-season-zine-by-daniels
25. "*Everything Everywhere All at Once*," A24: For Your Consideration, n.d., https://a24awards.com/film/everything-everywhere-all-at-once/index.html.
26. Geoff King, "Indie as Organic: Tracing Discursive Roots," in *A Companion to American Indie Film*, ed. Geoff King (Oxford: Wiley Blackwell, 2017) 58–79.
27. Glenn Whipp, "Review: After an Exhausting 2020, the Gentle 'Minari' Is the Movie We Need Right Now," *Los Angeles Times*, December 10, 2020, www.latimes.com/entertainment-arts/movies/story/2020-12-10/minari-review-steven-yeun.
28. Ono and Pham, *Asian Americans and the Media*, 157–63.
29. Erin Franziska Högerle, *Asian American Film Festivals: Frames, Locations, and Performances of Memory* (Berlin: De Gruyter, 2021)
30. Victoria M. Huỳnh, "Minari: Unsettling 'Belonging' to Asian/Amerika," Reappropriate, January 25, 2021, https://reappropriate.co/2021/01/minari-unsettling-belonging-to-asian-amerika/; Jane Kim, "Film Review: 'Minari,' an American Story," Asian American Christian Collaborative, February 12, 2021, https://www.asianamericanchristiancollaborative.com/article/minari-film-review; Yonhap, "Director Chung Says Theme of Universal Humanity in 'Minari' Resonates with American Audience," *Korea Herald*, January 14, 2021, www.koreaherald.com/view.php?ud=20210114000970.
31. Kristen J. Warner, "In the Time of Plastic Representation," *Film Quarterly* 71, no. 2 (Winter 2017): 34.
32. Melissa Phruksachart, "The Bourgeois Cinema of Boba Liberalism," *Film Quarterly* 73.3 (Spring 2020) 63-64.
33. I should acknowledge that Asian American film festivals, too, are gatekeepers, selecting films and bestowing awards. Furthermore, if we look beyond fiction filmmaking, Asian American documentaries and experimental films have received mainstream attention and distribution through educational and nontheatrical distributors like Third World Newsreel, Women Make Movies, and the Center for Asian American Media (CAAM). Public television, in cooperation with CAAM, has also been a selective and trend-setting financier and exhibitor of Asian American documentary.
34. I discuss these three liminal cases within the larger context of the emergent Asian American feature film in "The Coin of the Realm: Valuing the Asian American Feature-Length Film," in *Routledge Companion to Asian American Media*, ed. Lori Lopez and Vincent N. Pham (London: Routledge, 2017) 63–64.
35. Gregg Araki, "The (Sorry) State of (Independent) Things," in *Moving the Image: Independent Asian Pacific American Media Arts*, ed. Russell Leong (Los Angeles: UCLA Asian American Studies Center, 1991) 69.
36. "Filmmaker Lee Isaac Chung and critic Jeffrey Overstreet in Conversation," *Image*, [February 4, 2021], https://imagejournal.org/2021/02/24/chung-overstreet/.
37. Susette Min, *Unnamable: The Ends of Asian American Art* (New York: NYU Press, 2018); Vivian L. Huang, *Surface Relations: Queer Forms of Asian American Inscrutability* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2022).

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